

Rationalism — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Western Philosophy | Topic 02

This is the topic's solved Mains/PYQ workbook and transfer manual. All **15 directly owned** verified PYQs through 2026 receive complete independent model answers. These are learner practice, never official UPSC answer keys. The 2026 Aristotle–Leibniz entelechy question is cross-linked, not duplicate-owned.

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What to recall and what to write

Demand	Recall first	Write for marks
Rationalism/Descartes	five tenets; reconstruction chain	map each tenet to a Cartesian stage, then test the Circle
Substance	shared definition; 3–1–infinity	explain why stricter independence/simplicity changes the count
God	guarantor–identity–selector	role, proof/derivation, metaphysical cost
Mind-body	interaction–parallelism–harmony	mechanism, freedom criterion, strongest objection
Freedom	will–adequacy–compatibilism	define freedom before ranking the systems
Spinozist necessity	P16, P29, Def. 7	necessity is not fatalism; activity remains graded

Must-write keywords

Descartes: methodic/hyperbolic doubt; intuition and deduction; *cogito*; thinking thing (*res cogitans*); clear and distinct perception; innate/adventitious/factitious ideas; objective reality; divine veracity; extended thing (*res extensa*); real distinction; interactionism; finite intellect/infinite will.

Spinoza: self-caused (*causa sui*); God or Nature (*Deus sive Natura*); substance–attribute–mode; immanent cause; *natura naturans/naturata*; P15/P16/P18/P29; parallelism (II, P7); inadequate/adequate ideas; striving (*conatus*); bondage; aspect of eternity (*sub specie aeternitatis*).

Leibniz: monad; perception; appetite; apperception; minute perceptions; windowlessness; identity of indiscernibles; Principle of Sufficient Reason; complete individual concept; truths of reason/fact; possible worlds; pre-established harmony; spontaneity–intelligence–contingency.

High-value analytical lines

- Rationalism is a thesis about the **warrant of necessity**, not hostility to every sensory input.
- The *cogito* is strongest as a performative certainty and weakest when inflated into a complete metaphysics of an enduring immaterial substance.
- Descartes uses God to bridge an epistemic gap; Spinoza abolishes the gap by making God the immanent system; Leibniz uses God to select and synchronise a plurality.
- The substance count 3–1–infinity records progressively different tests of independence, not three accidental definitions.
- Parallelism does not coordinate two substances; it expresses one modal order under two attributes.
- Spinoza saves freedom by revising it from alternative choice to adequate self-determination.
- Leibniz saves contingency by separating certainty from logical necessity, but the complete concept keeps the libertarian objection alive.

- “All determination is negation” illuminates dependence only if negation of independence is not confused with negation of modal reality.

Introduction bank

1. **School:** “Early-modern rationalism seeks necessity through reason, innate structure and deduction, yet its shared method generates sharply different ontologies.”
2. **Substance:** “Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz inherit one independence criterion but enforce it with different strictness, producing the sequence three, one and infinitely many.”
3. **Spinoza:** “Spinoza's system converts epistemology, metaphysics and ethics into one order: adequate thought understands the same necessity that bodies express.”
4. **Comparative:** “The rationalists agree that reality is intelligible; they disagree over whether intelligibility requires interaction, identity or pre-established correspondence.”

Conclusion bank

- “Descartes establishes the rationalist programme, but its reconstruction is only as secure as the divine guarantee on which it depends.”
- “Spinoza gains unity and intelligibility at the price of contingency, personality and robust individuality.”
- “Leibniz restores plurality and agency, but harmony risks relocating rather than solving the coordination problem.”
- “The strongest verdict is graded: specify which conception of freedom, substance or explanation the thinker secures, and name the price.”

Redrawable diagrams and answer spines

SUBSTANCE: DESCARTES 3 -> SPINOZA 1 -> LEIBNIZ infinity
 criterion: attributes independence simplicity + activity
 cost: interaction individuality pre-programmed harmony

10 marks: define -> reconstruct 2-3 moves -> one objection/reply -> verdict
 15 marks: thesis -> complete argument -> qualification -> criticism/reply -> judgement
 20 marks: conceptual map -> philosopher-wise derivation -> comparison -> objections -> graded verdict

Argument/counterargument table

Claim	Strong objection	Best reply	Remaining difficulty
Clear and distinct ideas ground certainty	Cartesian Circle	occurrent clarity before God; memory needs guarantee	proof still appears mutually supporting

Claim	Strong objection	Best reply	Remaining difficulty
External bodies cause sensory ideas	God could directly cause them	divine non-deception plus natural inclination	relies on disputed theology
One substance follows from independence	finite modes disappear	modes are real expressions, not substances	individuality remains derivative
Necessity is compatible with freedom	no alternative possibilities	freedom is adequate self-causation	revision may abandon free will
Complete concepts preserve contingency	the actual act is fixed	opposite is logically possible in another world	agent-relative alternatives remain weak
Harmony preserves agency	coordination is miraculous	God establishes lawlike correspondence once	explanatory cost is transferred to God

Self-check rubric

Score each answer 0–2 on: exact demand; doctrinal accuracy; complete argument chain; source or textual anchor; objection and reply; explicit qualification; diagram/comparison where useful; signed verdict; exam-length control. **14–16:** ready; **10–13:** repair named cells; **below 10:** return to the Revision Guide and retry closed-book.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline — read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers; the 2019, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025 Paper I texts were read directly from the official question papers held in `books\philosophy_optional\`, the 2026 Q1(a) wording and marks were checked against the official OCR export and the verified 2026 ledger, and the 2018 and 2020 parts follow the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger because those two Paper I question papers are not present locally. Doctrinal claims are attributed to their Meditation, *Ethics* proposition or *Monadology* section, and interpretive disputes — whether the memory reply defeats the Cartesian Circle, whether "pantheism" or "panentheism" is the better label, whether Leibnizian contingency is more than epistemic — are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands are **10 marks — about 150 to 200 words, 15 marks — about 250 to 300 words, and 20 marks — about 340 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage: fifteen directly owned Rationalism PYQs from 2018 to 2026 — every part the ledger routes to this syllabus item, in every year of the corpus except 2021, which contains no primary-owned part — and six original solved Mains models, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks.

Citation discipline used in every answer. Spinoza is cited by structural reference (*Ethics* I, Def. 7; I, P15; I, P16; I, P18; I, P29; II, P7; II, P13; II, P40 Sch. 2; V, P32 Cor.), because those references are identical in every translation; Descartes is cited by *Meditation*, and by *Principles* or *Discourse* part where relevant; Leibniz is cited by *Monadology* section or by work. Renderings such as "monads have no windows" are marked as standard renderings rather than presented as literal originals.

2018 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: Is there any place for freedom in Leibniz's philosophy, when he speaks of 'pre-established harmony'? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Is there any place ...? Discuss" — a yes/no thesis is required, followed by exposition and assessment
Core issue	Whether denying causal interaction destroys agency or, on the contrary, secures it
Scope boundary	Ten marks: harmony, the three conditions of freedom, one necessity distinction, one verdict — no full monadology
Ideal thesis	Yes, but only compatibilist freedom: harmony <i>guarantees</i> spontaneity, and contingency survives through possible worlds
Non-negotiables	<i>Monadology</i> §7 windowlessness; spontaneity, intelligence and contingency; complete individual concept; hypothetical versus absolute necessity; "incline without necessitating"

Independent model answer

Pre-established harmony denies causal interaction among monads, but it does not reduce agency to external compulsion. Because monads have no windows, as *Monadology* §7 is usually rendered, each unfolds its states from its own internal principle of perception and appetite — so the very doctrine that removes outside influence is what **guarantees spontaneity**, the first condition of freedom.

Freedom additionally requires **intelligence** and **contingency**. A rational spirit acts for perceived reasons, not by blind impact. And although every predicate belongs to the individual's complete concept, Leibniz distinguishes certainty from absolute necessity: "Caesar crosses the Rubicon" is certain in the world God actualised, yet its opposite implies no contradiction and is realised in another possible world. God's selection under the Principle of Sufficient Reason makes the series **hypothetically**, not logically, necessary.

The difficulty is real. An act already contained in the complete concept seems unable to be otherwise *in this world*. Leibniz's answer is compatibilist: reasons "incline without necessitating" (*incliner sans nécessité*), and an action is free when it flows intelligently from the agent rather than from coercion.

Verdict. ⚠️ Harmony leaves a defensible place for responsible self-expression, but not for libertarian alternative possibilities.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2018 Q1(b): the question contains the word "any", so it must be answered directly before it is discussed. A script that expounds pre-established harmony and never says whether freedom survives has answered a different question.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: harmony and spontaneity in three lines; intelligence and contingency in four; the objection and the compatibilist reply in three; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** thesis → the three conditions → the strongest objection → a graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** windowlessness, appetite, complete concept, possible worlds, moral necessity.
- **Evidence:** *Monadology* §7; the Rubicon case; *incliner sans nécessiter* from the *Theodicy*.
- **Distinction:** hypothetical necessity versus absolute necessity — without it the answer collapses into fatalism.
- **Criticism:** concede that alternatives lie across worlds rather than within this one.

2018 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: What is the reason for the difference in the definitions and classifications of substances made by Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz in spite of the fact that they all belonged to the rationalist school of thought? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"What is the reason ...?" — explanatory , not descriptive; the answer is a mechanism
Core issue	One inherited definition, three degrees of strictness in enforcing it
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the shared definition, the three revisions with their criteria, costs, and a conceptual conclusion
Ideal thesis	Rationalism supplies the deductive ambition but not the substance count; the count is produced by how strictly "needing nothing else" is read
Non-negotiables	The shared definition; <i>Principles</i> I.51; no-shared-attribute and no-finite-substance steps; simplicity; well-founded phenomena; the dialectical sequence

Independent model answer

The difference arises not from abandoning rationalism but from successively tightening what counts as ontologically basic. All three inherit one definition — substance is what exists in itself and is conceived through itself, needing nothing else in order to exist — and they disagree only over how strictly to enforce it.

Descartes begins from clear and distinct **real distinction**. Thought and extension are mutually exclusive principal attributes, so mind and matter are created substances while God is infinite substance. Yet *Principles* I.51 concedes that only God needs nothing whatever; created things need God. "Substance" is therefore used **analogically**, and that concession is the hinge of the whole story.

Spinoza refuses the softening. In *Ethics* I, two substances cannot share an attribute, since nothing would then distinguish them as substances; and a finite substance would require limitation by another of the same nature. Hence exactly one infinite substance, God or Nature, exists, and minds and bodies become modes under Thought and Extension. The gain is unity and the dissolution of interaction; the cost is that finite individuality and alternative possibilities both weaken.

Leibniz rejects both extended Cartesian substance and Spinozist absorption. Extension is divisible and therefore composite, so it cannot be ultimate; true substances are simple centres of perception and appetite — infinitely many monads. The identity of indiscernibles differentiates them and pre-established harmony explains their correspondence without influx, while bodies become well-founded phenomena.

Revision	Criterion enforced	Result	Price
Descartes	real distinction by principal attribute	dualist created substances under God	equivocation, and an unintelligible interaction
Spinoza	absolute independence	one infinite substance	individuality and contingency weaken
Leibniz	simplicity plus internal activity	infinitely many monads	correspondence must be bought from God

Verdict. ⚠️ "Substance" is not a discovery but a **criterion**, and the metaphysics you obtain is the criterion you enforce. The sequence is therefore dialectical: Spinoza is the consistent Descartes, and Leibniz is the consistent rejection of extension as an essence. Each revision solves its predecessor's problem and immediately generates a new one, which is why no fourth position is available inside the same vocabulary and why the argument ends only when the vocabulary itself is attacked. The trio demonstrates rationalism's internal development rather than its incoherence.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2018 Q2(a): the examiner asks for a *reason*, so a table of three views is not an answer. The mechanism — one definition, three degrees of strictness — must be visible in the opening paragraph.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: shared definition in three lines; each thinker in a compact paragraph naming his criterion, his result and his cost; a comparative grid; a conceptual verdict.

- **Structure:** common premise → mechanism of divergence → comparative costs → conclusion at the conceptual level.
- **Doctrine:** real distinction; no shared attribute; no finite substance; simplicity; indiscernibles; well-founded phenomena.
- **Evidence:** *Principles* I.51 as the concession Spinoza exploits.
- **Distinction:** analogical versus univocal use of "substance".
- **Criticism:** each revision solves the predecessor's problem and generates its own.

2019 · Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: How does Descartes prove the existence of things other than himself and God? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he prove ...? Discuss" — reconstruct the argument, then assess it
Core issue	The Meditation VI causal argument, and its dependence on divine veracity
Scope boundary	Ten marks: five steps and one evaluation — no general survey of the <i>Meditations</i>
Ideal thesis	The proof is theological in structure: what secures the world is not the vividness of experience but the impossibility of divine deception
Non-negotiables	Passive faculty; active cause; great natural inclination; no correcting faculty; extension secured more strongly than sensible qualities; the wax excluded

Independent model answer

After the thinking self and the proof of a non-deceiving God, Descartes argues in Meditation VI that material things cause his involuntary sensory ideas.

The argument runs in five steps. Sensory ideas arrive **involuntarily**, so he possesses a **passive faculty** of receiving them. A passive faculty requires an **active cause** containing that reality. The cause is not himself, since the ideas come unbidden. He has a **great natural inclination** to refer them to bodies, and no faculty by which that inclination could be corrected. Therefore, if no bodies existed, a perfect God would be permitting an uncorrectable systematic error — that is, deceiving. ∴ Material things exist as **extended** realities.

Two limits must be stated. The proof secures **extension and body** far more securely than the literal accuracy of any colour, size or distance; the senses are reliable for what benefits the mind–body union, and reason must correct them. And the wax argument, which showed that bodily identity is judged by intellect, proves nothing about existence.

Verdict. ⚠ Descartes proves an external material cause *within his system*, but the result is only as secure as divine veracity — and therefore inherits Arnauld's Circle.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2019 Q1(d): "how" is a demand for a reconstruction. Naming God without the five steps forfeits most of the marks available.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: placement in one line; five numbered steps in six; two limits in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** locate the proof in the arc → reconstruct → limit → evaluate.
- **Doctrine:** passive faculty, active cause, natural inclination, divine veracity.
- **Evidence:** Meditation VI, with Meditation III supplying the non-deceiving God.
- **Distinction:** existence of body versus accuracy of sensible qualities.
- **Criticism:** the theological dependence, and the wax exclusion, both stated explicitly.

Question: What do you understand by Spinoza's statement that what is, cannot be other than what it is? Explain.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain" — foreground the derivation ; do not restate the sentence in other words
Core issue	Necessitarianism: modes follow from what substance <i>is</i> , not from a decree
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: derivation, three clarifying distinctions, the ethical consequence, one criticism with a reply
Ideal thesis	Necessity is logical-ontological rather than fatalistic, and it is the premise of Spinoza's ethics rather than its refutation
Non-negotiables	<i>Ethics</i> I, P16; I, P29; I, Def. 7; II, P7; contingency as ignorance of causes; <i>sub specie aeternitatis</i>

Independent model answer

The statement expresses Spinoza's **necessitarianism**. God, or Nature, is the one self-caused substance, and *Ethics* I, P16 holds that infinitely many things in infinitely many ways follow from the necessity of the divine nature. Modes are not products of choice; they follow from what substance is, as conclusions follow from adequate premises. The derivation is ontological, not a narrative in which God exists first and produces a world afterwards.

Three distinctions clarify the claim. First, God is **free** not because God could have chosen otherwise but because God is determined by nothing external — *Ethics* I, Def. 7. Second, **contingency** is a name for human ignorance of causes; I, P29 denies contingency in nature outright. Third, finite things are determined by **other finite modes** within the single causal order, so the necessity is immanent rather than imposed from outside.

This does not entail passive fatalism. Under Thought an adequate idea understands a cause; under Extension the same order is expressed bodily — II, P7. A person becomes relatively free by replacing inadequate passions with adequate activity and seeing things under the aspect of eternity (*sub specie aeternitatis*).

Critics reply that necessity erases responsibility and novelty. Spinoza answers that blame founded on an uncaused will was confused from the start, and that ethical improvement consists in increasing rational power. He can add that P29 removes contingency from nature rather than from deliberation, so practical reasoning keeps its place inside the necessary order instead of being abolished by it.

Verdict. ⚠️ The reply preserves self-determination and abandons the ability to do otherwise; that trade is the doctrine, not an accident of it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2019 Q2(c): "explain" is marked on the derivation. The three distinctions in the middle paragraph are what convert a paraphrase into an explanation.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: derivation in five lines; three distinctions in five; the ethical consequence in four; criticism and reply in three; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** derive → distinguish → apply → object → rule.
- **Doctrine:** immanent necessity; contingency as ignorance; freedom as self-determination.
- **Evidence:** P16, P29, Definition 7, II P7 — all structural references.
- **Distinction:** necessity is not fatalism, because no external agent compels.
- **Criticism:** responsibility, answered by the redefinition of blame.

2020 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: How does Leibniz's conception of monads bear upon his views on determinism and freedom? Discuss with your own comments.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Discuss with your own comments" — an explicit first-person evaluative paragraph is being marked
Core issue	How windowlessness produces both determination and self-expression
Scope boundary	Ten marks: monadic structure, the two consequences, and a signposted personal verdict
Ideal thesis	Monadology yields coherent compatibilism, not indeterministic freedom
Non-negotiables	Perception and appetition; windowlessness; complete concept; harmony; the three conditions; a first-person paragraph

Independent model answer

Monads are simple, windowless substances whose states arise internally through **perception** and **appetition**. Consequently an agent is never mechanically pushed by other substances; conduct expresses the agent's own **complete individual concept**. This supports **determinism**, since the whole sequence is certain to God and coordinated by pre-established harmony.

Yet Leibniz treats internally sourced rational action as **free**. Freedom combines **spontaneity**, which windowlessness itself guarantees, **intelligence**, since a rational spirit acts for perceived reasons, and **contingency**, because other possible worlds contain alternative individuals and histories. Reasons incline the will without necessitating it in the way a contradiction necessitates a truth.

In my own assessment, the account succeeds in distinguishing coercion from self-expression and preserves responsibility better than Spinoza's strict necessitarianism, because the agent is genuinely the source of what it does. But the actual agent's complete concept is fixed, so the availability of alternatives *in other worlds* may not satisfy a libertarian who demands that *this* agent, now, could do otherwise.

Verdict. ⚠️ Monadology yields coherent compatibilism, not indeterministic freedom.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2020 Q1(b): "with your own comments" is an instruction, not a courtesy. The paragraph must be signposted in the first person and must contain a judgement, not a summary.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: monadic structure and determination in four lines; the three conditions in four; the personal paragraph in four; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** structure → determination → freedom → personal adjudication.
- **Doctrine:** perception, appetite, complete concept, harmony.
- **Evidence:** *Monadology* §7 and the possible-worlds framework of the *Theodicy*.
- **Distinction:** certainty for God versus logical necessity.
- **Criticism:** the libertarian's demand, conceded rather than dismissed.

2020 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: "From the necessity of the divine nature there must follow infinitely many things in infinitely many ways." Explain this statement by Spinoza along with some possible criticisms.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain ... along with some possible criticisms" — two limbs, both compulsory
Core issue	<i>Ethics</i> I, P16 and the doctrine of immanent causation
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: derivation, four consequences, three criticisms each with a reply
Ideal thesis	P16 buys extraordinary systematic unity at the price of personality, contingency and robust individuality
Non-negotiables	Infinite attributes; immanent versus transitive cause (P18); denial of contingency (P29); acosmism; good and evil as relational

Independent model answer

In *Ethics* I, P16 Spinoza derives the world from the essence of the one infinite substance. God has infinitely many attributes, each expressing eternal and infinite essence; therefore infinitely many modes follow in infinitely many ways. The relation is **immanent causation** — P18 makes God the immanent, not the transitive, cause — so modes are *in* God rather than external products of a transcendent artisan.

Four conclusions follow. God does not deliberate between worlds; divine action is necessary. Nothing is genuinely contingent, since P29 denies contingency and reduces it to ignorance of causes. Thought and Extension express the same order under different attributes. And finite beings possess reality as modes, not as independent substances. Because the causation is immanent, the world is not a product standing outside its maker but the determinate self-expression of what God already is.

Three criticisms follow, each with a reply. First, necessity threatens divine personality and worship: a God without choice resembles an impersonal order. Spinoza accepts the consequence and rejects anthropomorphism, but providence and petition are genuinely lost. Second, Hegel's **acosmism** objection holds that if only substance is real, the finite disappears. Spinoza replies that modes are real *as determinate expressions*, though not self-subsistent. Third, strict derivation seems to make evil and bondage divine necessities. Spinoza answers that good and evil are relational notions tied to human power, not properties of infinite substance — yet suffering still belongs, unredeemed, to the necessary order.

Verdict. ⚠️ P16 gives Spinoza unmatched systematic unity at the price of personality, contingency and robust individuality.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2020 Q4(b): the second limb is not optional. Three criticisms *with replies* is the shape that earns the evaluative marks.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: derivation in four lines; four consequences in four; three criticism–reply pairs in nine; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** derive P16 → list consequences → object, reply, residual → rule.
- **Doctrine:** immanent causation, infinite attributes, denial of contingency.
- **Evidence:** P16, P18, P29 — structural references only.
- **Distinction:** immanent versus transitive cause, which is what makes the derivation non-temporal.
- **Criticism:** three distinct costs, each answered and each with a residue named.

2022 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: Discuss the concept of substance according to Spinoza. Does his discussion on substance lead to pantheism? Substantiate your view.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Substantiate your view" — you must take a side and defend it with textual grounds
Core issue	Whether monism entails pantheism, and in what precise sense
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the four-step demonstration, attributes and modes, the verdict, and the acosmism defence
Ideal thesis	Yes — qualified pantheism: nothing exists outside God, but God is not exhausted by the visible world
Non-negotiables	No shared attribute; no finite substance; P15 and P18; <i>natura naturans</i> and <i>naturata</i> ; panentheism as an alternative label; Hegel's acosmism

Independent model answer

Spinoza defines substance as what is **in itself and conceived through itself**. In *Ethics* I, no two substances can share an attribute, since nothing would then distinguish them as substances; and substance cannot be finite, because limitation requires another of the same nature. Therefore exactly one absolutely infinite substance exists, possessing infinite attributes: **God, or Nature**.

Thought and Extension are the two attributes known to human beings; particular minds and bodies are **modes**. *Ethics* I, P15 states that whatever is, is in God, while P18 calls God the **immanent**, not the transitive, cause. God does not stand outside and create Nature; *natura naturans* names the free active cause and *natura naturata* the order of modes that follows.

My view is that this does lead to pantheism, in a precise sense: all reality is within and expressive of God, and nothing exists independently outside God. It is **not** the crude identification of God with an aggregate of finite objects, because substance possesses infinitely many attributes and is not exhausted by the two we know. ⚠️ The **panentheist** reading, on which all things are in God while God exceeds them, therefore qualifies the label without erasing it — and interpreters genuinely dispute which term is better.

Hegel's **acosmism** charge presses from the opposite direction: if only substance is real, the finite becomes unreal. Yet modes possess dependent reality as determinate expressions of substance, and dependence is not nullity.

Verdict. ⚠️ Spinoza is best described as a philosophically **qualified pantheist**: divine immanence is undeniable, while divine infinity prevents reduction to the visible world alone.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2022 Q2(c): the directive forbids fence-sitting. The words "my view is" must appear, and the position must then be defended against the strongest counter-reading.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: the demonstration in five lines; attributes and modes in four; the declared verdict in five; acosmism in three; final ruling in two.

- **Structure:** define → demonstrate → declare → defend → rule.
- **Doctrine:** attribute, mode, immanent cause, active and produced nature.
- **Evidence:** P15 and P18, with the no-shared-attribute step reconstructed.
- **Distinction:** pantheism, panentheism and acosmism kept apart.
- **Criticism:** the acosmism charge answered by dependent-but-real modal reality.

2022 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: How does Rene Descartes explain the notion of certainty with reference to knowledge of the self? Critically discuss the way it differs from the knowledge of the world.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically discuss" — the assessment must dominate the second half
Core issue	The asymmetry between immediate self-knowledge and mediated world-knowledge

Element	Requirement
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: how certainty is reached, what the self is known as, how the world is known, and what the asymmetry costs
Ideal thesis	The epistemic priority of self over world survives, but the metaphysical dualism built on it does not follow without further argument
Non-negotiables	Methodic doubt; the <i>Meditations</i> formulation; <i>res cogitans</i> ; the wax; divine veracity; Lichtenberg and Hume; the Circle

Independent model answer

Descartes reaches certainty by methodically suspending every belief vulnerable to sense-error, dreaming or an evil genius. In Meditation II, "I am, I exist" is true whenever thought occurs, because deception itself requires a deceived thinker. Knowledge of the self is therefore **immediate, performative and independent of sensory mediation**.

The self is first known as a **thinking thing** (*res cogitans*): a thing that doubts, understands, affirms, denies, wills, imagines and seems to sense. Every item on that list is a mode of one attribute, thought, so the self is disclosed as a unity rather than as a bundle of separate faculties. The wax case strengthens the priority claim: even if the wax does not exist, the act of judging discloses the judging mind. Hence mind is *notior* — better known — in the strict sense of **more indubitable**.

Knowledge of the world is **mediate**. Sensory ideas represent objects but can mislead; an external world is restored only after God's existence and non-deceptiveness are established in Meditations III and V, through the involuntariness of sensory ideas and an uncorrectable natural inclination. Even then, intellect identifies body's essence as extension while reason corrects sensible appearances.

Critically, the *cogito* proves thinking existence, not automatically an enduring immaterial substance. Lichtenberg's later remark that Descartes was entitled only to "there is thinking", and Hume's bundle critique, both target that slide. ⚠️ Moreover, the world-proof inherits Arnauld's Circle, since the divine guarantee is established by reasoning whose earlier premises are remembered rather than attended.

Verdict. The asymmetry in **certainty** stands, because self-presence survives the hypothesis under which world-presence is doubted; the **metaphysical** dualism built upon it needs the separate argument of Meditation VI.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2022 Q4(b): two limbs, and the second is where "critically" is marked. The criticism must attack the *inference from certainty to substance*, not merely list objections to Descartes generally.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: route to certainty in four lines; the self as *res cogitans* in four; mediated world-knowledge in five; criticism in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** how certainty is reached → what is known → how the world differs → what the difference cannot support.
- **Doctrine:** performative certainty; *res cogitans*; divine veracity; extension as essence.
- **Evidence:** Meditations I, II, III and VI in their proper order.

- **Distinction:** epistemic priority versus metaphysical substantiality.
- **Criticism:** Lichtenberg and Hume on the subject; Arnauld on the bridge.

2023 · Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: "That thing is said to be free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature, and is determined to action by itself alone." Discuss Spinoza's views on freedom and determinism in the light of the above statement.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Discuss ... in the light of the above statement" — the quotation must be interpreted , then used
Core issue	Freedom opposed to compulsion, not to causation
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the definition, the illusion of free will, God's absolute freedom, human relative freedom, one verdict
Ideal thesis	Freedom is a higher form of determination, not an exception to causation
Non-negotiables	<i>Ethics</i> I, Def. 7; the conscious-stone image; adequate versus inadequate ideas; only God absolutely free; the concession about alternatives

Independent model answer

The quotation is *Ethics* I, Definition 7, and its key word is "alone": freedom is contrasted with **external compulsion**, never with causation.

Spinoza therefore rejects freedom as uncaused choice. Every finite mode is determined within Nature's necessary order, and human beings imagine themselves free because they are **conscious of their desires** but **ignorant of the causes** that determine them — as a thrown stone would, if conscious, believe it chose to fly.

Only **God is absolutely free**, because only God exists and acts from the divine nature alone, without external determination. Human freedom is **relative** and achieved. When inadequate ideas and external affects determine us we are passive and in bondage (*servitus*); when adequate ideas make us the **adequate cause** of our action, we act from our own understood nature. Reason and intuitive knowledge (*scientia intuitiva*) therefore convert necessity into self-determination, culminating in the intellectual love of God.

⚠ The account is coherent but revisionary: it preserves rational agency and emotional liberation while denying alternative possibilities altogether.

Verdict. Spinoza reconciles freedom with determinism by making freedom a **higher form of determination**, not an exception to causation.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2023 Q1(c): the quotation is the whole frame. Opening by interpreting "by itself alone" immediately signals that the definition has been understood rather than copied.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: interpret the quotation in two lines; the illusion in three; God and human freedom in five; concession and verdict in three.

- **Structure:** interpret → deny free will → grade freedom → concede → rule.
- **Doctrine:** adequate versus partial causation; bondage and action.
- **Evidence:** Definition 7 and the conscious-stone image, both Spinoza's own.
- **Distinction:** compulsion versus causation — the single most important line in the answer.
- **Criticism:** alternatives never return, stated as a concession rather than concealed.

2023 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: Discuss Descartes' theory of innate ideas and the grounds on which Locke refutes it.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Discuss ... and the grounds" — two limbs, and both must be given at full strength
Core issue	Whether Locke refutes the strongest Cartesian version or only the caricature
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the threefold classification, the argument from insufficiency, dispositional innateness, Locke's tests, adjudication
Ideal thesis	Locke defeats occurrent innatism decisively and dispositional innatism far less clearly
Non-negotiables	Adventitious, factitious, innate; objective reality of the idea of God; dispositional innateness; universal assent; transparency of mental content; sensation and reflection

Independent model answer

Descartes distinguishes **adventitious** ideas that seem to arrive from outside, **factitious** ideas voluntarily constructed, and **innate** ideas native to the mind's rational nature. Innate ideas are not necessarily explicit propositions present in an infant's consciousness; they are native capacities or contents, including God, substance, mind, extension and mathematical principles. In Meditation III the idea of an infinite perfect being grounds the causal or trademark argument, precisely because a finite mind cannot be its adequate total cause.

Locke attacks innate principles in the *Essay concerning Human Understanding*, Book I, on two principal grounds. **Universal assent is absent:** children and persons without the relevant concepts do not affirm the alleged principles. And saying that principles are "in the mind" but unknown **empties innateness of meaning**, because by that standard every knowable truth would already be innate. He offers instead a mind that is white paper, furnished by **sensation and reflection**.

Descartes can reply that innateness means a **dispositional** power, not constant awareness; geometrical knowledge is elicited rather than copied from sensation, and no accumulation of measured figures yields necessity. ⚠️ Locke's argument therefore defeats **occurrent** innatism decisively, but defeats **dispositional** innatism far less clearly. The empiricist, in turn, must still explain necessity and universality without merely reporting repeated experience.

Verdict. Locke narrows the defensible Cartesian claim from preformed conscious truths to native cognitive structures; he refutes the caricature more securely than the strongest version, and the residual burden — a criterion distinguishing an innate disposition from a bare capacity to learn — falls on Descartes.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2023 Q2(c): both theories must be given at their strongest. A weak Descartes makes Locke's victory worthless and forfeits the adjudication marks.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: classification and the argument from insufficiency in five lines; Locke's two tests in five; the dispositional reply in four; verdict in three.

- **Structure:** classify → argue → object → reply → adjudicate.
- **Doctrine:** objective reality of ideas; dispositional innateness; sensation and reflection.
- **Evidence:** Meditation III; *Essay* Book I.
- **Distinction:** occurrent versus dispositional innatism — the hinge of the whole answer.
- **Criticism:** the residual burden is named and assigned, rather than left open.

2024 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: How does Spinoza establish that God alone is absolutely real with his statement — "Whatever is, is in God"? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically discuss" — evaluation must dominate the closing half
Core issue	How P15 is <i>established</i> , and what "in" means
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the substance argument, the meaning of "in", P18, then three objections with replies
Ideal thesis	God alone is <i>absolutely</i> real; finite things are real <i>relationally</i> , which is monism without world-denial
Non-negotiables	The no-shared-attribute step; absolutely infinite substance; ontological not spatial "in"; P18 immanent cause; individuality, change, personality

Independent model answer

Spinoza's conclusion follows from his substance argument. Substance is what is in itself and is conceived through itself; no two substances can share an attribute; and an absolutely infinite substance must possess every attribute. Therefore God alone is substance, and *Ethics* I, P15 concludes that everything else exists **in** God as a mode.

"In God" is **ontological, not spatial**. A mind is a mode under the attribute of Thought and a body a mode under Extension; neither can be conceived independently of substance. The preposition therefore records dependence in conception as strictly as dependence in existence. P18 adds that God is the **immanent** cause of things — the cause remains in the effect rather than producing something outside itself. God is therefore absolutely real because divine existence and conception depend on nothing else, while finite reality is derivative.

The view avoids a creator–world dualism and explains parallelism elegantly. Yet it faces three objections. The **individuality** of modes appears weakened, since a mode is not conceivable apart from substance. **Modal change** is hard to reconcile with an eternal, immutable substance. And a **personal, providential** God disappears entirely.

⚠ Spinoza can reply that independent reality is not the only kind of reality; that temporal order belongs to the causal series of finite modes rather than to substance; and that personality would anthropomorphise infinity. Each reply is defensible, and each leaves a residue.

Verdict. God alone is absolutely real, but finite things are not nothing: they are real **relational expressions**. This makes Spinoza a monist and a qualified pantheist without committing him to simple world-denial.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2024 Q2(b): the question says "how does he establish". The demonstration must precede the interpretation, and the interpretation must fix the meaning of the preposition.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: the argument in four lines; the meaning of "in" and P18 in five; three objections in four; replies and verdict in five.

- **Structure:** establish → interpret → object → reply → rule.
- **Doctrine:** absolutely infinite substance; mode; immanent causation.
- **Evidence:** P15 and P18, reached by reconstruction rather than assertion.
- **Distinction:** absolute reality versus modal, relational reality.
- **Criticism:** individuality, change and personality, each answered and each leaving a residue.

2024 · Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: Among the rationalists, whose account of mind-body problem is compatible with the notion of human freedom and free will? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A comparative ranking with a defended winner; neutrality is a failure condition
Core issue	Compatibility depends entirely on the criterion of freedom adopted
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: all three accounts, an announced criterion, a defended ranking, and the winner's cost

Element	Requirement
Ideal thesis	Leibniz, on a compatibilist criterion — Descartes wins on a libertarian criterion but at an unpayable price
Non-negotiables	Interaction and Elisabeth's objection; <i>Ethics</i> II, P7 and necessitarianism; windowlessness and harmony; the three conditions; explicit criterion

Independent model answer

Compatibility depends on the criterion of freedom, so the criterion must be declared first.

Descartes' interactionism separates unextended mind from a mechanically determined body, permitting a libertarian will that can affirm, deny or withhold assent. But Princess Elisabeth's objection of 1643 remains unanswered: no intelligible account explains causal commerce between substances sharing no property, and the pineal gland supplies only a location. Descartes' own reply — that the union is a primitive notion — preserves the phenomenon and abandons the mechanism.

Spinoza dissolves interaction by making mind and body the same mode under Thought and Extension (*Ethics* II, P7). This is metaphysically economical, but it entails necessitarianism: freedom becomes adequate self-determination, and free will as alternative choice is expressly denied. It also abandons ordinary mental causation, since no idea moves a limb, so the economy is bought by revising the very experience the question begins from.

Leibniz denies interaction because windowless monads unfold internally, and pre-established harmony coordinates the mental and bodily series. Rational action remains **spontaneous, intelligent and contingent**, because the actual world is one possible world chosen by God, so truths about action are certain but not absolutely necessary.

⚠ If "free will" means the ability to do otherwise, Descartes wins — with an unintelligible causal theory. If it means responsible agency compatible with systematic determination, **Leibniz** offers the strongest account. Spinoza offers the deepest self-mastery but openly rejects free will.

Verdict. Leibniz is the best-qualified answer, because his mind–body theory preserves internal agency and moral responsibility without Cartesian interaction — though it remains compatibilist rather than libertarian, and buys correspondence from God in advance.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2024 Q3(c): the fatal error is describing all three neutrally. Announce the criterion in the first line, rank explicitly, and defend the ranking.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: criterion in one line; three accounts in twelve; the ranking in four; verdict with its cost in three.

- **Structure:** declare the criterion → run all three → rank → defend → concede the price.
- **Doctrine:** interaction, parallelism, harmony; the three conditions of Leibnizian freedom.
- **Evidence:** Elisabeth's 1643 objection; *Ethics* II, P7; *Monadology* §7.
- **Distinction:** libertarian versus compatibilist criteria, stated before any ranking.
- **Criticism:** the winner's cost is named, which is what makes the ruling look considered.

Question: What are the basic tenets of Rationalism? How does Descartes build a system of Philosophy in consonance with them? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two limbs, the second much larger; "discuss" requires assessment as well as exposition
Core issue	Mapping each tenet onto a stage of Descartes' system, not describing them separately
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: five tenets, seven stages, then a load-bearing critique
Ideal thesis	Descartes does not merely assert the tenets; he constructs a system that embodies them as its operating logic
Non-negotiables	The five tenets; four rules and hyperbolic doubt; the <i>cogito</i> ; innate ideas; the three proofs; divine veracity; substance metaphysics; will and intellect; the Circle

Independent model answer

Rationalism holds that reason can yield **necessary and universal** knowledge through innate or self-evident principles, deduction and an intelligible structure of reality. Its tenets are: innate cognitive resources; reason as the ground of necessity; intuition and deduction as method; the intelligibility of the real; and a metaphysics of substance, attribute and mode. Experience may occasion thought, but it cannot alone provide the certainty that mathematics models.

Descartes embodies these tenets as a system, stage by stage.

1. **Method over authority.** The four rules of the *Discourse*, Part II, and hyperbolic doubt reject inherited opinion and demand evident beginnings.
2. **A self-evident foundation.** The *cogito* is grasped by intellectual intuition and survives the evil genius; it is not inferred from sensory evidence.
3. **Innate content.** Ideas of God, substance, mind, extension and mathematical truths are native to rational cognition, elicited rather than copied from sensation.
4. **Deductive reconstruction.** From the thinking self Descartes argues to a perfect God by the trademark, conservation and ontological routes.
5. **Intelligibility and truth.** A non-deceiving God underwrites clear and distinct perception, restoring mathematics and, through involuntary sensory ideas and an uncorrectable natural inclination, the external world.
6. **Substance metaphysics.** Reality is ordered into infinite God and the created principal attributes of thought and extension.
7. **Mechanistic nature and rational freedom.** Extended nature is mathematically governed, while the infinite will can withhold assent; error occurs when it outruns the finite intellect.

The system is rationalist not merely because it praises reason but because **each stage seeks necessity independent of sensory contingency**. The wax argument even makes intellect, rather than sense, the judge of bodily identity.

⚠ Its vulnerabilities are equally systematic. The *cogito* may prove only occurring thought, not a Cartesian substance. The trademark and ontological arguments are disputed. Arnauld's Circle suggests that the divine guarantee presupposes the criterion it secures. Locke attacks innate principles, and Kant later denies that existence is a real predicate.

Verdict. Descartes constructs the paradigm rationalist system — foundational, innate, deductive and substance-based — but its success beyond the *cogito* depends on theological premises less indubitable than its own method demands.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2025 Q2(a): the first limb is the smaller one. Spending half the answer on the tenets and rushing the system inverts the marks.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: tenets in four lines; seven numbered stages in fourteen; the unifying observation in three; four vulnerabilities in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** define the school → map every tenet onto a stage → identify the unifying logic → evaluate the load-bearing weaknesses.
- **Doctrine:** all five tenets instantiated, in order, with named Cartesian material at each stage.
- **Evidence:** *Discourse II*; *Meditations I–VI*; *Principles I.51*.
- **Distinction:** praising reason versus constructing a system whose operating logic *is* reason.
- **Criticism:** four independent lines of attack, each aimed at a named stage.

2025 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: "All determination is negation." Comment with reference to Spinoza.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Comment" — short, pointed, thesis-first ; not a general essay on Spinoza
Core issue	What the formula means <i>inside</i> Spinoza's monism, and where it actually comes from
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: provenance, meaning, one consequence each for God, modes and knowledge, then a judgement
Ideal thesis	The dictum illuminates dependence but becomes reductive if limitation is mistaken for unreality
Non-negotiables	Letter 50 provenance and Hegel's universalisation; infinite substance as pure affirmation; modes limited by modes; <i>sub specie aeternitatis</i> ; the acosmism exchange

Independent model answer

The formula is associated with Spinoza's **Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles of 2 June 1674** — "determination is negation" — and was universalised into the Latin slogan by Hegel, which is how it entered the textbook tradition. ⚠️ It is not a sentence of the *Ethics*, and saying so is itself part of a correct comment.

Its meaning is this. To determine a finite thing is to bound it as *this* rather than *that*; every limit excludes alternatives. Finitude therefore contains negation.

In Spinoza's metaphysics three consequences follow. **For God**: substance is absolutely infinite and determined by nothing external, so God involves no negation whatever and is pure positive self-expression through infinite attributes. **For finite modes**: each is limited by other modes of the same nature — a body occupies this region and excludes others, a particular idea expresses only a bounded causal perspective — so their determination marks dependence and limitation. **For knowledge and freedom**: inadequate knowledge treats a finite thing in isolation, whereas adequate knowledge understands it through the affirmative whole of Nature, and the free person sees limitation and necessity under the aspect of eternity (*sub specie aeternitatis*) rather than imagining an independent will.

Hegel's criticism is that Spinoza's infinite may swallow all finite determination, turning the world into negation — the **acosmism** charge. ⚠️ Spinoza can answer that what is negated is *independent self-subsistence*, not every form of reality: modes positively express divine power in determinate ways.

Verdict. The dictum illuminates why finite beings are dependent, but it becomes reductive if limitation is mistaken for unreality. Spinoza needs **both** the negation of independence and the affirmation of modal expression.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2025 Q2(b): "comment" is a demand for a pointed thesis, not an essay. The provenance line earns a mark on its own and should open the answer.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: provenance in three lines; meaning in two; three consequences in eight; the acosmism exchange in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** correct the provenance → state the meaning → three consequences → adjudicate the objection.
- **Doctrine:** infinite substance as pure affirmation; mutual limitation of finite modes.
- **Evidence:** Letter 50; the Hegelian reception; *sub specie aeternitatis*.
- **Distinction:** negation of independence versus negation of reality.
- **Criticism:** acosmism raised at full strength and answered without evasion.

2026 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: How does Spinoza explain the relationship between states of mind and bodily processes?

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does" requires the metaphysical basis and the working mechanism, not a generic mind-body survey

Element	Requirement
Core issue	One individual is expressed under Thought as mind and under Extension as body
Scope boundary	Ten marks: substance/attributes, II P7, denial of cross-attribute causation, one implication and one criticism
Ideal thesis	Spinoza replaces Cartesian interaction with identity of order under distinct attributes
Non-negotiables	God or Nature; attributes; modes; <i>Ethics</i> II P7; parallelism; no mental-to-physical causal traffic

Independent model answer

Spinoza rejects the Cartesian picture of two substances that must somehow interact. There is only one substance, God or Nature, possessing infinitely many attributes, of which human beings know Thought and Extension. A particular mind and its body are therefore not two independent things: they are **one and the same finite mode expressed under two attributes**.

This grounds *Ethics* II, Proposition 7: “the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things.” Every bodily process has a corresponding idea, but the mental event does not push the body and the bodily event does not manufacture the idea. Causal explanation remains within an attribute: ideas are explained through ideas and bodies through bodies. Their exact correspondence follows because both express the same immanent causal order of substance.

The account eliminates Princess Elisabeth's interaction problem and explains systematic psychophysical correlation without a pineal bridge. Its cost is necessitarianism: both series unfold within Nature's determined order, so freedom cannot mean an uncaused will. Spinoza instead defines freedom as activity from adequate understanding.

Verdict. The relation is best called parallelism or double-aspect identity: no interaction between mind and body, but one reality intelligibly expressed in two ways.

Qualification and criticism

“Parallelism” is useful shorthand, but it must not suggest two independently running substances. The view explains correspondence economically, yet the claim that two attributes express one mode can seem asserted rather than independently demonstrated, and it revises ordinary agency.

Why this earns marks

It begins with Spinoza's ontology, states II P7, distinguishes correspondence from causation, derives the freedom consequence, and closes with a qualified classification.

Exam-length execution

10 marks, about 150–200 words: ontology in three lines; II P7 and the no-interaction mechanism in five; explanatory gain and cost in three; verdict in one.

Closed-book answer spine

one substance -> Thought/Extension -> one mode in two expressions -> II P7 -> no cross-attribute causation -> parallelism -> freedom recast

Cross-link without duplicate ownership — 2026 Q1(d)

The question "Compare and contrast the notion of entelechy as presented in Aristotle's and Leibniz's philosophy." is primarily owned and fully solved in [Topic 01 Plato and Aristotle](#). For this topic recall only the Leibnizian half: a created entelechy is a simple, internally active substance with perception and appetite; Aristotle's *entelecheia* denotes actuality or realised completion rather than a separate simple substance.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Six original questions in the examined format — two at 10 marks, two at 15 and two at 20 — with complete model solutions. These are practice questions written for this package; they are not previous-year questions and are not official keys.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why the wax argument remains necessary to Descartes' rationalist project even after the *cogito* has been established. Discuss.

Independent model answer

The *cogito* establishes only that thinking existence is indubitable whenever thought occurs. The wax argument of Meditation II extends the result by showing **how bodily identity is cognised at all**.

A fresh piece of wax loses taste, scent, shape, hardness and sound near the fire, yet is judged without hesitation to be the same wax. Neither a fixed sensory catalogue nor imagination — which cannot run through the indefinitely many shapes that "flexible and changeable" (*flexibile et mutabile*) requires — explains that judgement. Only mental scrutiny (*inspectio mentis*) does.

The case therefore supports two rationalist claims. First, the **intellect contributes** the concept of an extended, flexible, changeable thing. Second, every judgement about the wax more certainly reveals the **judging mind**, even if the object should not exist. The "hats and coats" example makes the same point about ordinary seeing, which is in fact judging.

⚠ Two limits must be conceded. The argument presupposes extension as body's essence, and an empiricist may call that essence an abstraction. It proves intellectual structuring more clearly than innate knowledge.

Verdict. The wax converts the *cogito* from a bare existential certainty into an **epistemological priority claim**: mind is the condition under which body can be known at all.

Why this earns marks

- Answers "why necessary" directly rather than retelling the example.
- Reconstructs the argument, including the elimination of imagination.
- Names a second Cartesian example in one line.

- States a precise limitation instead of closing with praise.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: "Spinoza's God does no explanatory work outside the system." Examine this claim by comparing the role of God in Descartes and Spinoza.

Independent model answer

For **Descartes**, God is a **bridge**. The *cogito* yields one certainty; divine veracity converts a rule read off that single case into a general licence to trust clear and distinct perception, and then licenses belief in an external world. Remove God and the system contracts to isolated intuitions.

For **Spinoza**, God is not an added cause but the **system itself**. God, or Nature, is the one substance; Thought and Extension are its attributes; minds and bodies are its modes. *Ethics* I, P18 makes God the immanent, not the transitive, cause, so nothing is produced outside God and nothing needs to be certified from outside.

The claim is therefore largely correct. Descartes' God performs an **external epistemic function** and can fail — exactly what Arnauld's Circle alleges. Spinoza's God performs no such function, because no gap between knower and known requires bridging: the order of ideas simply *is* the order of things (*Ethics* II, P7).

⚠ One qualification is needed. Spinoza's God does other work: it grounds the necessity and intelligibility of everything that follows.

Verdict. Descartes' God is a **guarantor** and can be attacked; Spinoza's God is a **structure** and can only be rejected wholesale.

Why this earns marks

- Uses a single comparative axis — the explanatory role of God — rather than describing two theologies.
- Cites P18 and II, P7 structurally.
- Concedes a qualification instead of over-claiming.
- Ends with a distinction that could be reused in any comparative question.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Is Spinoza's freedom merely determinism under a more attractive name? Critically examine.

Independent model answer

Spinoza is a strict **necessitarian**: *Ethics* I, P29 denies contingency in nature, and every finite mode is causally determined by other finite modes. If freedom requires the ability to do otherwise under identical conditions, his theory is indeed determinism renamed, and he would not dispute the description.

Yet *Ethics* I, Definition 7 distinguishes **external** determination from action flowing from one's own nature. Human bondage (*servitus*) consists in inadequate ideas and passive affects produced by partial causal understanding; through common notions, reason and intuitive knowledge (*scientia intuitiva*), a person

becomes the **adequate cause** of what follows from their own ideas. The conscious-stone analogy attacks ignorance of causes, not agency as such.

This is more than rhetorical relabelling for three reasons. The distinction between being an adequate and a partial cause is a real difference in the causal structure of an event. Understanding an affect changes one's relation to it and increases the power of acting, so the doctrine has practical consequences. And *Ethics* III, P6–P7 make striving (*conatus*) the actual essence of a thing, so acting from one's nature is not a fiction but the exercise of what one is.

⚠ Two concessions are unavoidable. Every achievement of understanding is itself necessitated, so nobody could have failed to become free who does. And alternative possibilities never return at any stage.

Verdict. Spinoza offers a substantive **compatibilist ideal of self-mastery**, not free will in the libertarian sense. Whether that counts as freedom depends on whether freedom is defined by **authorship** or by **alternatives** — and the disagreement is best left openly at that point rather than disguised.

Why this earns marks

- States both criteria of freedom before ruling.
- Gives three independent reasons why the position is substantive.
- Uses *conatus* only as far as it supports the argument.
- Concedes precisely, and locates the residual disagreement in a definition.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Examine the claim that Descartes' interaction problem is not a defect of his system but a direct consequence of his own criterion of truth.

Independent model answer

The claim is substantially correct, and stating why is the whole answer.

Descartes' criterion is that whatever is perceived **clearly and distinctly** is true. Applied to mind and body, it yields the real distinction of Meditation VI: I conceive myself clearly as a thinking, unextended thing, and body clearly as an extended, unthinking thing; whatever can be clearly conceived apart, God can create apart; therefore they are really distinct substances.

But the same criterion fixes their essences as **mutually exclusive**. Thought is defined so as to exclude extension, and extension so as to exclude thought. Causal influence, however, appears to require some community between cause and effect. The two substances share nothing whatever, so there is no property through which influence could pass. ⚠ The interaction problem is therefore not an oversight but the **direct consequence** of the very clarity that produced the dualism.

Descartes' responses confirm the diagnosis. The pineal gland supplies a **location**, not a mechanism. His considered reply to Princess Elisabeth in 1643 — that the mind–body union is a **third primitive notion**, known through ordinary living rather than pure intellect — concedes that the union cannot be conceived by the faculty that established the distinction.

One qualification is fair. Descartes never claimed that everything real must be transparent to pure intellect; the union is presented as a datum of experience rather than a deduction.

Verdict. The problem is generated by the system's own success. Clarity buys the distinction and pays for it with unintelligibility — which is why Spinoza and Leibniz do not repair Cartesian interaction but **replace** the premise that produced it.

Why this earns marks

- Converts a familiar objection into an internal diagnosis.
- Traces the problem to the criterion rather than to an isolated mistake.
- Uses Elisabeth's objection and the primitive-notion reply as evidence, not decoration.
- Concedes a fair qualification and still delivers a ruling.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "The history of rationalist substance is a movement from dualism through monism to pluralism." Analyse the logic and the cost of this movement.

Independent model answer

The sequence three, one, infinitely many captures a real dialectic, but its logic lies in **changing criteria** rather than in a preference for numbers. All three thinkers seek self-explanatory reality accessible to reason; they differ over what makes something ontologically basic.

Descartes uses principal attributes and real distinction. God is infinite substance; mind and body are created substances whose essences are thought and extension. The gain is a clear basis both for a mathematical physics and for personal consciousness. The cost is a definitional equivocation, conceded in *Principles* I.51, and an interaction problem that his own criterion generates.

Spinoza applies independence consistently. If substance is conceived through itself, dependent created substances cannot qualify; and substances sharing an attribute cannot be distinguished. God, or Nature, alone remains, while minds and bodies become modes under Thought and Extension. The gain is unity and the dissolution of interaction, since the order of ideas is the order of things. The cost is necessitarianism and the threat of acosmism.

Leibniz accepts that extended composites are not ultimate but refuses to sacrifice individuals. Simplicity, perception and appetite define infinitely many monads; the identity of indiscernibles guarantees their uniqueness. The gain is active plurality and internal agency. The cost is that bodies become well-founded phenomena and that correspondence requires pre-established harmony and a divine selector.

Movement	Problem solved	New problem generated
Descartes → Spinoza	dependence and interaction between created substances	finite individuality and contingency weaken
Spinoza → Leibniz	restores genuine individual centres of activity	harmony and complete concepts strain explanation

⚠ The movement is therefore neither linear progress nor arbitrary disagreement. Each successor enforces one rationalist demand more strictly and pays elsewhere, because coherence, individuality and experiential plausibility cannot all be maximised at once.

Verdict. Rationalist substance evolves through **internal criticism**, and the lesson is conceptual rather than historical: the definition of the basic unit already contains a theory of causation, of individuality and of freedom, so choosing a criterion of substance is choosing a metaphysics. That is also why the movement terminates only when Locke and Hume attack the innate resources which made the vocabulary of substance available in the first place.

Why this earns marks

- Analyses a movement rather than describing three positions.
- Attaches a named gain and a named cost to each stage.
- Uses a compact grid to make the dialectic visible.
- Concludes at the conceptual level, which is what "analyse" demands.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the roles assigned to God in the systems of Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz, and assess which system depends on God most heavily. Critically discuss.

Independent model answer

The three systems assign God three different jobs, and the depth of dependence is not the same in each.

Descartes: God guarantees. The *cogito* yields one certainty. Divine veracity, established by the trademark and conservation proofs of Meditation III and the ontological proof of Meditation V, converts a criterion read off that single case into a general licence, and then underwrites memory, extended reasoning and the inference from involuntary sensory ideas to an external world.

Spinoza: God is the system. God, or Nature, is the one absolutely infinite substance; Thought and Extension are attributes expressing its whole essence; minds and bodies are modes. *Ethics* I, P15 makes everything exist in God, and P18 makes God the immanent, not the transitive, cause. Nothing is produced outside God, so nothing needs to be certified from outside.

Leibniz: God selects and harmonises. The Principle of Sufficient Reason demands a necessary being outside the contingent series; God surveys infinitely many compossible worlds and actualises the most perfect — the greatest variety under the simplest laws — and arranges all monads at creation so that their internally unfolding states correspond.

⚠ **The assessment.** Dependence must be measured by what collapses if the divine premise fails. Remove Descartes' God and the system contracts to the momentary *cogito*: mathematics, memory and the world all go. Remove Leibniz's God and there is no reason why *this* compossible set is actual and no source of the harmony, so the correspondence between mind and body becomes a brute coincidence. Remove Spinoza's God and there is no system left to have lost anything — but that is because God is not a premise within the system, it is the system.

The paradox is instructive. Spinoza's God is the most **pervasive** and the least **vulnerable**, because it is not inferred from a concept of perfection; this is why Kant's objection that existence is not a real predicate bears directly on Descartes and Leibniz and leaves Spinoza largely untouched.

Verdict. Judged by fragility, **Descartes** depends on God most heavily, since a single contested proof carries his entire epistemology; judged by pervasiveness, Spinoza does, since God is not a support but the substance of everything asserted. Naming which sense of "depends" is in use is what turns this comparison into an argument.

Why this earns marks

- Uses one matched axis — the job God performs — across all three systems.
- Applies a genuine test: what collapses if the divine premise is removed.
- Distinguishes two senses of "depends" and rules on both.
- Adds Kant only as a one-line rider, respecting the ownership boundary.